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The Kingdom of Siam

The Art of Central Thailand, 1350–1800



Forrest McGill, Editor and Curator

M. L. Pattaratorn Chirapravati, Co-Curator

*Essays by Forrest McGill, Dhiravat na Pombejra, Hiram Woodward,
Santi Leksukhum, M. L. Pattaratorn Chirapravati, and Henry Ginsburg*

*Entries by Forrest McGill, with M. L. Pattaratorn Chirapravati,
Tushara Bindu Gude, and Natasha Reichle*

Photography by Kaz Tsuruta and others



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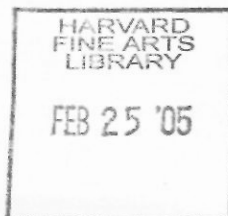
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Introduction to the History and Culture of the Kingdom of Siam



Forrest McGill

The great and fortunate capital Ayutthaya was founded in 712 of the Era, Year of the Tiger, Second of the Decade [1351]. . . . The court brahmans calculated the auspicious moment to carry out the ritual of warding off evil omens. A clockwise-turning conch shell was obtained from under a *man* bush. Then three palaces . . . were constructed. Then Prince U Thong, at the age of thirty-seven years, entered and commenced his reign. The brahmans presented him with the title "His Majesty King Ramadhipati . . . of the City of the Gods, Excellent Great Capital Dvaravati Shri Ayudhya, Great Nine-Jeweled Ornament of the World, Royal City Abounding in Delights."

The foundation of the city and kingdom of Ayutthaya (called Siam by foreigners) sounds straightforward enough in this account from the Royal Chronicles.¹ But the Chronicles as they have come down to us were compiled centuries after the events described, and of course present an official narrative intended to enhance royal prestige. Trying to understand something of Ayutthaya's early history is by no means easy. Records are few and difficult to interpret.² What buildings and artworks remain from the decades before and after the kingdom's founding are often ruinous, or heavily restored, and assigning them dates – not to speak of attempting to interpret them in historical and cultural context – is mired in uncertainty and contention.

The century prior to the ceremonial founding of Ayutthaya had seen rapid change in mainland Southeast Asia.³ The once-great kingdom of Angkor in Cambodia weakened, ceasing – after many hundreds of years – to build huge state temples and to compose inscriptions in learned Sanskrit.⁴ Other major powers in the region, the kingdoms of Dai Viet in northern Vietnam and Pagan in north-central Burma, faced a host of challenges that led, eventually, to profound change in the one and the collapse of the other.⁵

A number of jostling competitor states surrounded Siam in its early years. Siam itself incorporated the earlier principalities of Suphanburi to the west and Lopburi, sometimes under the domination of Angkor and sometimes independent, to

the east. Further to the west was Ra-manyā, the Mon-speaking area of southern and eastern coastal Burma. To the north lay the Thai-speaking kingdom of Sukhothai, which Siam would struggle for generations to dominate. An adversary in this struggle was the next kingdom to the north, Lan Na, centered at Chiang Mai, which also sought to dominate the territories of Sukhothai. To the east was a reduced, but still significant Angkor, with which Siam shared important cultural traditions, while continuing to vie for power and status. On the southern horizon lay the proud old peninsular city of Nakhon Si Thammarat, now a major Siamese provincial capital, and beyond, the Malay world, into which had begun to appear the Muslim merchants and travelers who presaged the conversions to Islam of the next two centuries.

Scholars of past generations tended to emphasize kings and battles, religious developments, and, to a lesser extent, trade, as shaping forces in the history of mainland Southeast Asia between 1350 and 1800. In recent years they have paid ever more attention to trade, and have investigated other sorts of forces – climate change, epidemics, advances in technology, the introduction of new crops and livestock – with illuminating results.⁶ These new approaches have yielded insights with implications for our understanding of the culture of Siam. For instance, from about the seventh century to the ninth or tenth, the main polity in central Thailand (it may not have been centralized enough to be called a "kingdom")⁷ was Mon-speaking Dvaravati, the name of which is referred to in the long formal name of Ayutthaya quoted above. The art of Dvaravati and aspects of its Buddhist traditions had a degree of influence in early Siam. In 1981 two Thai scholars published research showing that, while Dvaravati towns and settlements were distributed over much of central Thailand, they were not found in the low-lying areas around Ayutthaya and southward beyond Bangkok to the sea. Correlation of the locations of Dvaravati remains with topographical maps and the findings of geographers suggests that the areas without



Left: fig. 2. Ceramics from the kilns of north-central Thailand, late fourteenth–sixteenth centuries. The spherical bottle is from the “Nanyang” shipwreck off the coast of Malaysia. Asian Art Museum, left to right, B66P4, The Avery Brundage Collection; 1989.34.29, 1990.130, 1989.34.34, The James and Elaine Connell Collection of Thai Ceramics; and F2001.50.5, Gift of Dennis Kending. Right: fig. 3. Wat Ratchaburana, Ayutthaya.

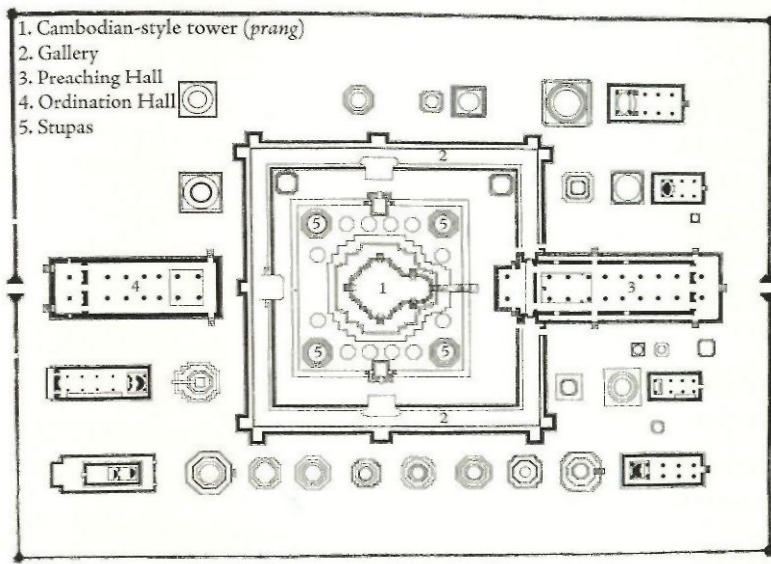
these remains were in fact below sea level, and that Dvaravati towns ringed the former coastline. It seems very likely that even in the early Ayutthaya period some of the land around and south of the city was swamp, and that making use of it for agriculture was a challenge.⁸

Who were the people of the new kingdom? The answer is not simple. The kingdom of Dvaravati was, according to the historian David Wyatt, “not nearly as monocultural (or monolingual, or monoethnic) as any of its major neighbors.” Its people used the Mon language, but this “does not necessarily mean that the people were ethnically Mon.... The actual population probably was very ethnically diverse, composed possibly of people who at another time might have been considered Mon, Khmer [Cambodian], Malay, Cham, or Karen, and who in later centuries might be successively ‘Khmer’ and ‘Thai.’”⁹ The situation in the Ayutthaya kingdom seems to have been similar. Generation by generation there were more speakers of Thai and fewer of Mon, but for centuries Ayutthaya’s official documents were often written in Cambodian, and Cambodian may have continued to be spoken fairly commonly.¹⁰

Another component of the new kingdom’s population – significant beyond their numbers – would have been Chinese and Indian traders and their descendents. The founding king himself is sometimes said to have been the son of a Chinese merchant,¹¹ and the exchange and transport of goods both local and foreign was a major source of the kingdom’s wealth throughout its history. Ceramics made in the Sukhothai region and exported through Ayut-

thaya in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries are found by the thousands all over island Southeast Asia (fig. 2). As will be seen, Ayutthaya became one of the richest entrepôts of Asia. Of course trade was more important to some parts of the kingdom than to others in its early years, and in various ways regional differences and regional interests made themselves felt.¹² Historians have noted that in the kingdom’s first century there seems to have been competition between one family with its power base in the Lopburi area in the east and another with its power base in the Suphanburi area in the west, and between their “Khmer-oriented” and “Thai-oriented” (or Sukhothai-oriented) outlooks.¹³ Signs of these differences and this competition appear in the arts as well, and have been thought to account for the simultaneous production of sculptures in different styles or modes.¹⁴

The religious life of early Ayutthaya was also by no means unitary. Foreigners and their descendents must have practiced varieties of Hinduism and Islam as well as Chinese religions. The Buddhism of the Siamese was itself a complex mix. In the background were the Mahayana and Hinayana strains of Dvaravati, the Vajrayana of the temple of Phimai in the northeast (completed approx. 1112),¹⁵ and the complicated royal Mahayana of Jayavarman VII of Angkor (1181–early 1200s). In central Thailand in the 1200s, what has been termed an “Ariya sect” of Hinayana Buddhism – characterized by a bundle of iconographic features such as Buddhas in groups of three – had been prevalent, and may have continued to exert influence in the early Ayutthaya period.¹⁶ By about



Left: fig. 4. Plan, Wat Ratchaburana, Ayutthaya. Right: fig. 5. Main tower, Wat Mahathat, Lopburi.

1400, Theravada Buddhism from Sri Lanka seems to have won the day in Siam (as in the other kingdoms of Thailand, as well as those of Burma, Laos, and Cambodia), but only by making room for local beliefs, spirit cults, and the importance of Hindu gods in court traditions.

Several Buddhist temples are named by the Royal Chronicles as having been founded during Ayutthaya's first century. The remains of these temples can still be seen, and would be thought to exemplify the early art and architecture of the Siamese kingdom. There are, however, a number of challenges to using them in this way, and these challenges suggest why the study of Ayutthaya-period art has progressed so slowly.

First, it is necessary to jump from the kingdom's early years to its last, to consider its conquest by the Burmese in 1767. According to the Chronicles,

The Burmese troops lit fires in every vicinity and burned down buildings, houses, hermitages, and the Holy Royal Palace Enclosure. Then they toured around to chase and capture people, and to search out and confiscate all their various sorts of valuables, whether silver or gold, or other belongings. Those who had removed their precious things and hidden them by burying them, the Burmese accordingly whipped, beat, and roasted to make them lead the way to their belongings. Then the Burmese used fire to melt off the pure gold which encased the large standing statue of the Holy Buddha within the Monastery of the Glorious Omniscient One. . . . As for all the families of the nobles and the commoners, the Burmese commander divided them up and swept them away [to Burma].¹⁷

Afterwards, the capital was largely abandoned and left to decay. Thus, in modern times, matching names of temples mentioned in the Chronicles with surviving ruins has sometimes proven difficult. Nor, as implied earlier, can the accuracy of the facts and dates in the Chronicles necessarily be taken for granted. One important Thai scholar has rejected much of what they say about early buildings, arguing, for instance, that Wat Ratchaburana (fig. 3), dated by the Chronicles to 1424, was in fact built sometime after 1687.¹⁸ (As will be seen, a date for Wat Ratchaburana of approximately 1424 is accepted by the authors of this publication.)

Even if the date given in the Chronicles for the founding of a temple is accepted, issues of what was built when still remain. Thai temples are complexes of several, even many, buildings and free-standing monuments, some of which clearly have been built decades or centuries later than others. Often, too, there is evidence of repeated repairs or alterations. Because the buildings were made of brick and stucco rather than of stone, surface decorations and reliefs frequently suffered damage over the years, and repairs may have covered or replaced original materials.

Nevertheless, enough evidence has come down to us to give a fair picture of the art and architecture of early Ayutthaya. The remains of such as complexes as Wat Phra Ram, said to have been founded in 1369, and Wat Mahathat, founded in 1374, suggest that the main components of the Siamese temple developed early. Among these were:



Above: fig. 6. Ruined gallery, Wat Mahathat, Ayutthaya. Opposite, top: fig. 7. Gallery, Wat Phra Chettuphon (Wat Pho), Bangkok. Bottom left: fig. 8. Ordination hall, Wat Na Phra Men, Ayutthaya. Bottom right: fig. 9. Stupa, Wat Mae Nang Plum, Ayutthaya.

THE CAMBODIAN-TYPE TOWER, OR PRANG

These towers (figs. 1 and 3 and cat. no. 55), ultimately related to those of Cambodian monuments such as Angkor Wat, evolved in Thailand from such models as the twelfth- to thirteenth-century central tower of Wat Mahathat in Lopburi (fig. 5).¹⁹ Built of brick covered and decorated with stucco, rather than of the stone of the Cambodian examples, the towers had a central sanctuary raised on a high base with layer upon layer of moldings. Four steep flights of stairs mounted to the level of the sanctuary from the four directions, but three of these stairs ended at false doorways. Only on the east was there a real opening to the sanctuary; this was often preceded by a forechamber. Above the sanctuary rose a tall, bullet-shaped superstructure decorated with rows of antefixes. Indentations at the corners of the whole structure continued from ground level to top, giving a strong sense of the vertical. From the summit of the tower projected a many-pronged finial. The Cambodian-type tower sometimes stood alone, or might be flanked by two similar but smaller towers, or might have four other towers (of various sorts) standing at its corners, forming a symbolically potent quincunx.²⁰

THE GALLERY

A major Cambodian-type tower, with or without other towers in relation to it, was usually situated in a courtyard surrounded by a square gallery (figs. 6, 7). The gallery would have presented a solid wall to the outside world, but was

open on the inside in a colonnade. The roofs, now vanished, must have been of wood and perhaps tiles. The sides of the gallery were lined with rows of Buddha images. Usually both the corners of the gallery and its midpoints were marked by special features such as larger Buddha images or higher, more ornate roofs.

THE ORDINATION HALL AND PREACHING HALL

Both were large rectangular buildings of stucco-covered brick, with wooden roofs (fig. 8). A very general impression of what they looked like is given by cat. no. 50. Inside would have been a large Buddha image usually surrounded by several, or many, others. The interior walls were no doubt painted with scenes from the present and previous lives of the Buddha and other religious subjects, but these have usually been lost to war and the elements. The ordination hall, in which various monastic ceremonies were conducted, stood on consecrated ground marked by eight boundary stones (cat. no. 49).

THE STUPA (FIG. 9)

A large stupa (or arrangement of stupas) sometimes stood at the center of a temple complex in place of a Cambodian-type tower. Smaller stupas, presumably memorializing high-ranking monks or nobles, or well-to-do citizens, might be erected in considerable numbers throughout the complex. Cat. nos. 53 and 54 exemplify the appearance of some late Ayutthaya stupas.



THE BUDDHA IMAGE

Buddha images were made in a variety of materials and in all sizes from tiny to colossal. The seated image to which a one-meter-tall stone face in the exhibition belonged (cat. no. 3) must have been over seven meters (twenty-three feet) in height, and a famous image at Wat Phanan Choeng across the river from the city of Ayutthaya (fig. 30), supposedly founded in 1324, is nineteen meters (over sixty-two feet) in height.²¹

In images, the Buddha is shown sitting, walking, standing, or reclining (cat. nos. 5, 8, 34, 46) with hands held in a variety of gestures. By far the most frequent pose in Ayutthaya-period art is seated with the right hand touching the ground below the right knee. This pose recalls the moment in the life story of the Buddha when, as he progresses

toward the attainment of buddhahood, he gains victory over the demon Mara by calling upon the Earth to bear witness to his worthiness.

THE NARRATIVE RELIEF

The walls or pediments of pre-Ayutthaya-period temples throughout Southeast Asia—both Buddhist and Hindu—often bore narrative reliefs of episodes from holy legends. Those of the temples of Ayutthaya must also have done so, but relatively few such reliefs (which in Ayutthaya would have been made of stucco or wood) survive. For those that do survive, it is often hard to determine how often they have been restored. Occasionally an artwork suggests what an early Ayutthaya narrative relief in architecture might have looked like (cat. no. 9, fig. 124).



Fig. 10. Ruins of palace buildings, Ayutthaya.

For secular art and architecture, the evidence is meager. As in the excerpt quoted at the beginning of this chapter, the Royal Chronicles note the construction and dedication of palaces in the kingdom's very first years, but nothing is left of any early palaces except foundations, and we can only imagine their appearance (fig. 10). Probably not until the 1600s were palaces built of brick rather than of wood. Few decorative art objects survive other than the jewelry, crowns, weapons, and ceremonial vessels deposited in the crypt of Wat Ratchaburana in 1424 (cat. nos. 16, 17, 18). This dated crypt is like a time capsule from Ayutthaya several generations after its founding. As M. L. Pattaratorn Chirapavati details in her essay in this catalogue, the crypt held hundreds of Buddha images, votive tablets, and decorative art objects of the sorts just mentioned. In a field such as the arts of early Ayutthaya, with much uncertainty and few fixed points, the discovery in 1957 of a trove of artworks necessarily created at or before a certain known date came as a revelation. Among the objects found in the crypt were coins from a Muslim court in Kashmir, amulets with Chinese inscriptions and wall paintings in Chinese style, and Buddha images from India, Tibet, and Sri Lanka.²² They testify to the significance of trade and foreign contacts for the kingdom of Siam in its first century. From the 1370s, kings had sent trading missions to China every two or three years, and sometimes more often; missions from China to Ayutthaya were not infrequent.²³ Trade with China (and Korea and Japan) was also conducted, from at least the 1390s, through the intermediary of the kingdom of Ryukyu (Okinawa).²⁴ The extended Indian Ocean trading network, connecting Siam with not only India and Sri

Lanka but also Persia and the Arab world, though less well documented, clearly was important from the beginning.²⁵ In all, a noted historian suggests, "until the late sixteenth century . . . [Ayutthaya] may have been the single most active Southeast Asian port."²⁶

Siam's relations with several of its close neighbors were characterized, in the 1400s, by its expansionism. The kingdom of Sukhothai, having been under increasing pressure from Ayutthaya for many decades, lost much of its autonomy in the 1430s and was incorporated as a province.²⁷ In the same decade, Angkor, with which Siam had long been skirmishing, fell to a Siamese invasion. The returning Thai forces brought back with them a number of large Angkorian bronze statues (some of which survive) and presumably cartloads of treasure and many prisoners.²⁸ In mainland Southeast Asia, with its low population densities, capturing large numbers of people and marching them back to the victorious kingdom was usually a higher priority in warfare than capturing and holding territory.²⁹ Captives with valuable knowledge and skills were particularly prized. It would seem likely that the art objects and the people—perhaps including artisans and ritual specialists—brought from Angkor to Ayutthaya would have had an impact on the arts of Siam, but such an impact has not yet been identified.

King Borommatrailokkanat, the son of the conqueror of Angkor, assumed the throne upon his father's death in 1448. His long reign is an important one for the arts, because several buildings he founded, and even a group of sculptures, are still extant, and give a picture of the arts of Siam in the mid-1400s. The group of sculptures, of which six are included in the exhibition (cat. nos. 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24), represent the Buddha in his former lives. The king probably commissioned them as part of an effort to counteract the ill effects of the arrival of the two-thousandth year after the Buddha's death. It seems to have been feared that this anniversary boded the accelerated disappearance of the holy teachings.³⁰ The sculptures fall into several distinct styles—those with knobby crowns and square faces, those with smooth crowns and long faces, and so on. They suggest that various workshops maintained independent traditions, and that uniformity of style had not been achieved and was not demanded.³¹

King Borommatrailokkanat spent a number of years in the important north-central city of Phitsanulok, to which, several decades earlier, the last independent king of Sukhothai had moved his capital. In Phitsanulok the Ayutthayan king built two versions of the Cambodian-type temple tower that seems to have been associated with Ayutthayan royal authority (figs. 11, 49).³² The king had moved north

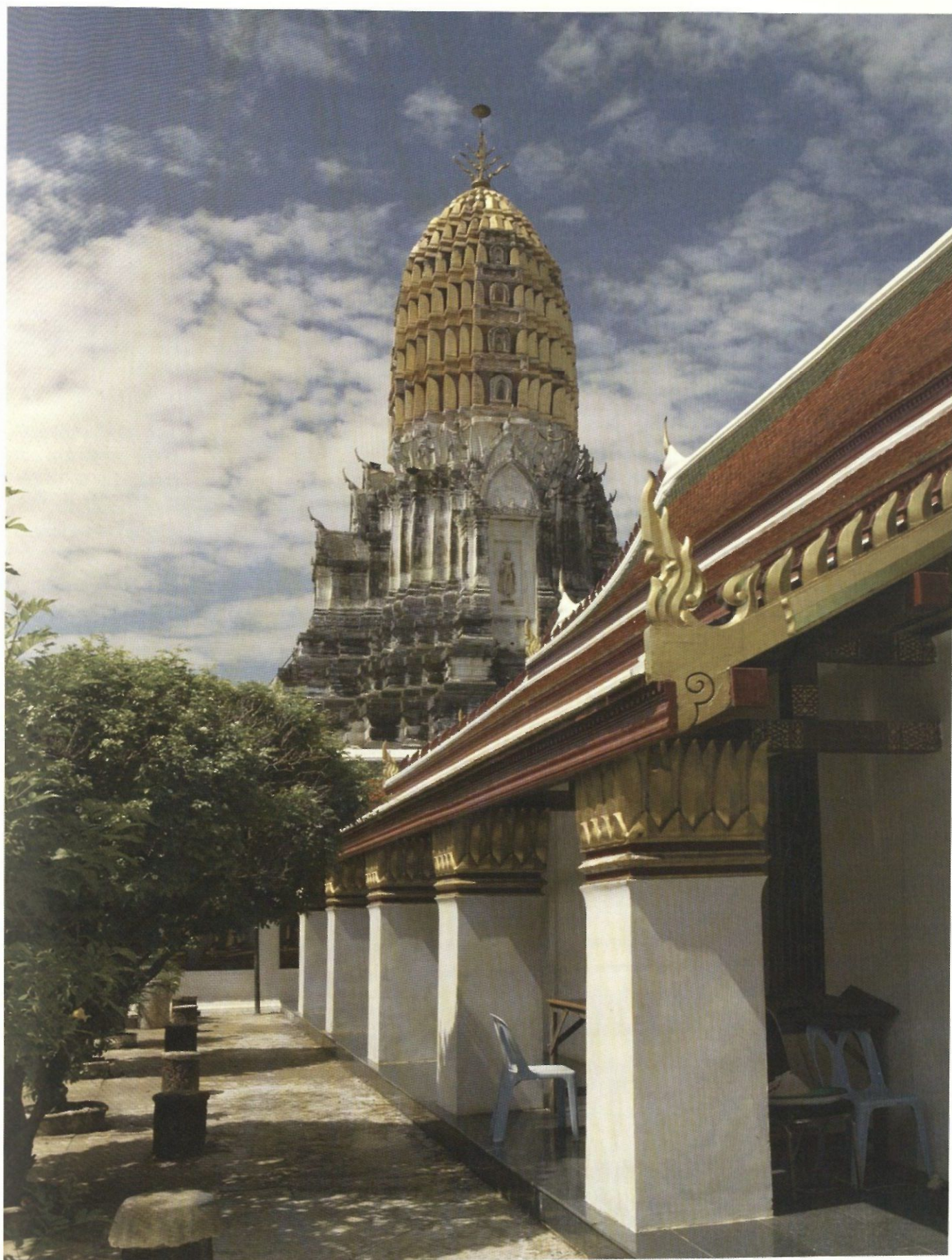


Fig. 11. Wat Mahathat, Phitsanulok.



Fig. 12. Face of the Shiva of Kamphaeng Phet, 1510.

in part to direct a long-running military struggle with Lan Na. What was at stake was control over the old territories of Sukhothai and, it seems, of their lucrative ceramic production. From the 1420s or before to the 1560s, wares from the many kilns of the region were widely exported through Ayutthaya,³³ and this trade must have been vital in allowing the Siamese court to obtain many needed or wished-for foreign goods such as high-quality weapons, textiles, Chinese porcelains, and exotic luxuries. The exhibition does not emphasize Thai ceramics, but includes one particularly elaborate example from the north-central kilns. Unlike most of these ceramics, which comprised dishes, bowls, bottles, and lidded boxes, this elephant with attendants (cat. no. 25) has no obvious utility, and must have served some symbolic or ritual purpose. But even lacking an everyday use, such elephants were in demand abroad; several have been found in Indonesia.³⁴

In the late-fifteenth-century battles between Siam and Lan Na ominous new weapons appeared: firearms. An arms race had begun that would push rulers to compete to acquire the latest Chinese and Persian – and, in the next century, the even more effective Portuguese – guns and cannon.³⁵ Also

needed, and competed for, were foreign mercenaries and specialists who could teach new military tactics, set up gun foundries, and design the heavy fortifications required to defend cities against explosives and cannon shot. The alloy composition of Thai (and Chinese) metal sculpture changed during the fifteenth century; were new techniques related to weapons production somehow an influence?³⁶

Though conflict with Lan Na continued, Siam entered a period of increased prosperity and power. In the years around 1500 the temple adjoining Ayutthaya's royal palace was enlarged with a new preaching hall, a colossal bronze Buddha image, large stupas serving as memorials to former kings (fig. 43), and probably other major buildings and images as well.³⁷ Of these, only the stupas and some Buddha images survive as more than ruins and fragments. In the exhibition, a pair of doors carved with guardian figures (cat. no. 29) came from this royal temple and may have been part of the additions of about 1500; a head from a Buddha image (cat. no. 32) suggests the "remote grandeur" associated with its Buddha images.³⁸

As far as is known, no major Cambodian-type temple towers were built in Siam during the 1500s, and the period has sometimes been seen as favoring Sri Lankan-related architectural and artistic forms, such as the bell-shaped stupa like those at the royal temple just mentioned. To put it another way, forms with orthodox Theravada Buddhist associations have been seen as favored over those associated with other strains of Buddhism, or with the worship of the Hindu gods.

Several facts complicate this view. The Royal Chronicles relate that, later in the reign of the king who expanded the main royal temple, there were discovered, during the dredging of a canal, metal images of "the Lord of the Hundred Thousand Eyes" and "the Lord Holding a Conch Shell," that is, the Hindu deities Indra and Vishnu. "The King had offerings made to them . . . a building was erected, and they were enshrined."³⁹ These images are not known to have survived, but must have been left from the days when central Thailand was under the dominance of the kingdom of Angkor. Furthermore, some years earlier, in 1510, the ruler of the north-central city of Kamphaeng Phet commissioned a group of large bronze statues of Shiva (fig. 12), Vishnu (cat. no. 37), and other Hindu deities in a strongly archaizing, Angkor-related style, and dedicated the merit of this act to his overlord in Ayutthaya.⁴⁰ Thus the Siamese court and its representatives do not appear to have been avoiding either the Hindu deities or associations with ancient Cambodia.

For much of the remainder of the 1500s, developments in the art and culture of Siam are not easy to follow, for lack



Fig. 13. Mainland Southeast Asia around 1540.

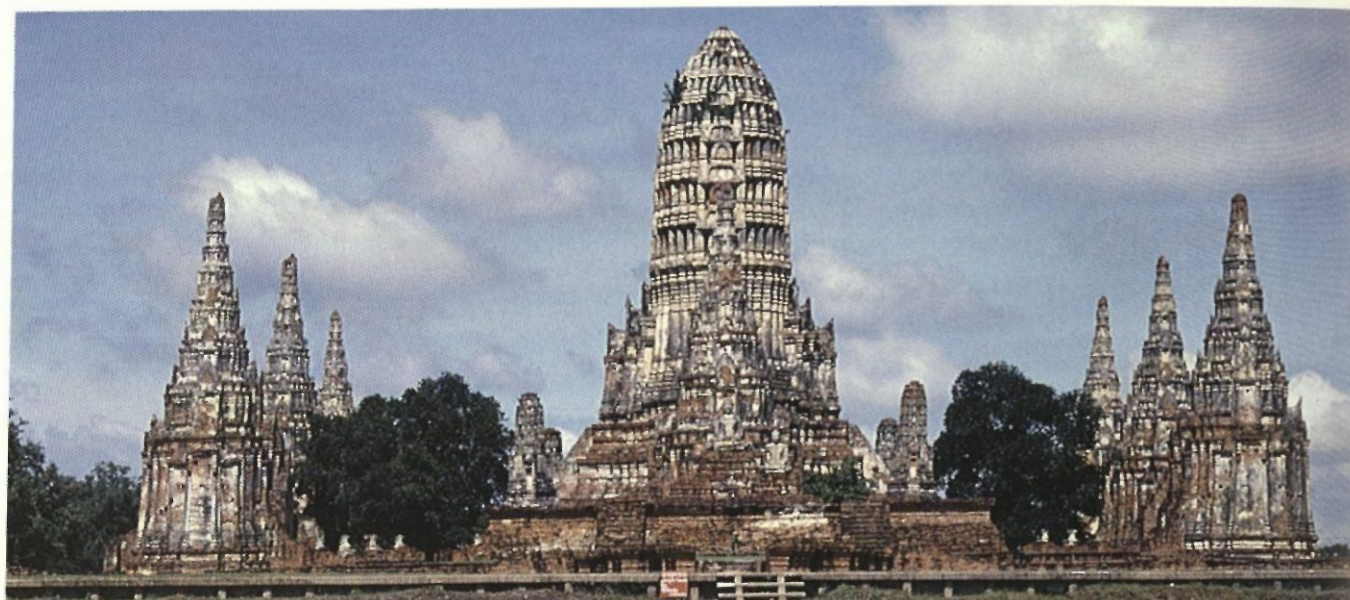


Fig. 14. Wat Chaiwatthanaram, Ayutthaya.

of dated works and other hard evidence. Clues are offered by another very large bronze Buddha (which survives; fig. 34) that may have been erected in Ayutthaya in about 1538. Some decades ago, during a restoration, a number of Buddha images were discovered in the shoulder of this image, where they may have been deposited when the image was made.⁴¹ Three of these are included in the exhibition: cat. nos. 33, 34, 35. They are not similar enough in style to lead us to believe that they were necessarily cast at the same time or place. But of course such ritual deposits could include old images as well as new, from far away as well as nearby. The whole group has not been studied in detail, and firm conclusions are not yet possible.

One of these images demands attention because it is of a type not yet mentioned, but to be of continuing importance: the standing crowned and bejeweled Buddha image: cat. no. 35; (compare cat. nos. 42, 43, 48, 63). Such images had been common in central Thailand in the 1100s and 1200s, but seldom appear again before 1500.⁴² Their meanings are not well understood, but it is conceivable that they memorialized deceased royal persons and prefigured their attainment of buddhahood in the future.⁴³

Other clues to developments in the arts of Siam in the 1500s come from another, much larger crowned Buddha image (cat. no. 42) from the Sukhothai area inscribed with a date equivalent to 1541. It differs in many details from its almost exact contemporary, the image from Ayutthaya just mentioned (cat. no. 35), and the issue of the persistence of regional traditions is again raised. For instance, the crown of the Sukhothai image is open at the top, allowing the

ushnisha and flame to project through; the crown of the Ayutthaya image is closed, and terminates, like most Ayutthaya crowns of the period, in a cone of tapering rings. Is this difference a matter of regional stylistic preference, or of symbolism? We do not know.

Part of the reason that the artistic developments of the later 1500s are so poorly understood is that in those years Siam was racked by wars and disorder, and its kings may not have had the time or resources to undertake large-scale projects. In fact, similar problems affected the entire region. An eminent historian speaks of "the collapse of virtually every Theravada state in Southeast Asia between c. 1550 and 1600."⁴⁴ Siam and the Lao kingdom of Lan Xang struggled over a weakened Lan Na, and the Cambodians raided eastern Siam. The Siamese attacked the Cambodian capital in 1555–1556. Succession disputes undermined the stability of Lan Na and the Lao kingdom. By 1564 Lan Na had been reduced to vassalage by the Burmese and would never fully regain its independence. The Burmese attacked Ayutthaya in 1549 and again in 1564 without taking it, though during the conflicts the Siamese queen, Suriyothai, the heroine of a recent movie, was killed. Eventually, in 1569, Ayutthaya fell to the Burmese and was sacked. The destruction was great, and much of the kingdom depopulated through war and deportations to Burma. Subsequently, the Burmese were able to take the Lao capital as well, and to depose the Lao king.

The Burmese victories did not last. In the 1580s Siam began to be able to reassert itself, and though bloody conflict continued for many years, by 1593 Siam had again secured



Fig. 15. Shrine of the Buddha's Footprint near Saraburi.

full autonomy. Meanwhile, the Burmese kingdom itself was disintegrating, and in 1599 invaders destroyed its capital.

Siam was again to enjoy an extended period of rapid economic growth and relative stability. Foreign trade was a primary source of the new wealth, and brought with it, as always, stimulating, and no doubt challenging, new ideas. The Chinese, Indians, and other Southeast Asians continued their important roles as merchants, but new players were entering the scene. The Portuguese had been trading with Siam for some time; in the years around 1600, the Japanese, Persians, and Dutch became active. For their part, the Siamese were eager for foreign contacts. Kings of Ayutthaya sent embassies to Holland in 1608 and to Japan in 1616.⁴⁵

The Royal Chronicles, which had preoccupied themselves with wars and strategies in their entries for the later decades of the 1500s, again describe temples, Buddhist and Hindu images, and imposing public ceremonies being sponsored by kings. The founding of a particularly important temple is detailed in the entry for 1630:

At the house of his mother the king caused to be built a great relic tower. It was encircled by a gallery that had *merus* arranged along it at intervals at the directional points, and consisted of an ordination hall and a preaching hall for religious instruction. There were also built a large number of cells to be presented to the monkhood. When it was completed it was given the name Wat Chaiwatthanaram [Monastery of Victorious Progress, fig. 14].⁴⁶

Wat Chaiwatthanaram is important for several reasons. First, its buildings and some of its Buddha images survive

in a fair state of preservation. Though they must have been repaired from time to time in the some 130 years from their construction until the fall of Ayutthaya, they seem likely to have retained their original form and character.⁴⁷ Thus, amidst all the uncertainty and scarcity of reliable dates in the history of Siam's art, they provide a store of forms and motifs attributable to the period between 1625 and 1650 (cat. no. 49).⁴⁸ Comparison with crowned and bejeweled Buddha images at Wat Chaiwatthanaram suggests that a rather similar image in the exhibition, cat. no. 47, dates from this period.

Second, Wat Chaiwatthanaram is an exceptionally ambitious and complex monument, larger than any built in Ayutthaya for more than a century. In it the king, drawing on venerable Siamese and Cambodian ideas, deployed the full range of Cambodian-type towers in quincunx, surrounding galleries, ordination and preaching halls, narrative reliefs, and Buddha images, and added to them the *merus* referred to in the Chronicles – towers named after the mythic central mountain of the Buddhist universe, and shaped like structures used for royal cremations – to create an elaborate microcosm in which were glorified both the Buddhist religion and his own exalted status.⁴⁹

No later king of Siam chose to attempt a project on this scale. Though Ayutthaya had by now been surpassed by Manila or Batavia (Dutch-colonial Jakarta) as Southeast Asia's most important entrepôt, trade flourished more than ever, and the influx of foreigners made the capital, in the 1670s and 1680s, arguably the most cosmopolitan city in Asia.⁵⁰ Perhaps it was less and less possible for so grandiose and recondite a monument as Wat Chaiwatthanaram to make its effect, or for a king to imagine that building one was a good investment.

The reign of King Narai (1656–1688) is the best documented period in the history of the Ayutthaya because of the missions he sent to various European and Asian courts and the extensive writings of French Jesuit missionaries and French and Persian envoys who visited his kingdom (cat. nos. 85, 86). Though often necessarily absorbed in the maneuverings of squabbling factions in his capital and of his neighbors' armies near his borders, he seems to have been exceptionally interested in overseas trade and foreign affairs, and hospitable to foreigners (and their local descendants) and their ways.⁵¹ He appointed as high government ministers a Persian and even a Greek, magnanimously welcomed the French (who had convinced themselves they might convert the king to Roman Catholicism), constructed buildings with European features, and set a fashion at court for wearing Persian-style garments with a Malay kris tucked in the sash (cat. no. 60).



Fig. 16. Prince Vessantara gives away his children, from a manuscript with paintings of the Three Worlds, cat. no. 79.

For all the documentation available for Narai's reign, not a great deal is known of the development of its arts (cat. nos. 56, 57, 58, 59, and 60 may date from the reign). The Royal Chronicles describe the casting of Buddha images and a number of statues of Shiva, Ganesha, and other Hindu deities, but none can be identified today.⁵³ One Chronicle entry describes a certain commissioned Buddha image in detail, saying that it was crowned and bejeweled and in the position of "restraining the ocean," that is, standing with both hands raised palm out. An example in the exhibition (cat. no. 63) is probably from some decades after Narai's reign. This type of image continued to be made in some numbers into the early twentieth century; in the early nineteenth, and perhaps before

and after, it was associated with memorializing deceased members of the royal family.⁵³

The end of Narai's reign saw a backlash against the French, and an increased wariness of Europeans seems to have lasted through the kingdom's final years. But "a wider employment at court of Indians, Malays, Persians, and Chinese easily compensated for a decline in European specialists" and a rise in trade with China counterbalanced a falling off in trade with Europe.⁵⁴

From the 1700s many more artworks – and types of artworks – remain than from previous centuries. Works in perishable materials, such as paintings on cloth and paper, pieces of furniture, wood and ivory carvings, even textiles, survive to delight us – and to remind us of the similar mate-

rials from Siam's earlier days that have vanished irretrievably: cat. nos. 52, 54, 67, 72, 74, 77, and 81. Oddly, both the history and the art history of the 1700s have been less studied, and are less well understood, than those of the 1600s.⁵⁵ European records and accounts are scarcer, and the Royal Chronicles themselves say relatively little about the commissioning of buildings and artworks, but a great deal about provincial rebellions, palace intrigues, hunts for auspicious white elephants, frequent pilgrimages to the Shrine of the Buddha's Footprint (fig. 15), and the inappropriate fondness of several kings for catching fish.⁵⁶

Restoration, as well as creating anew, was a primary artistic activity of the later kings of Ayutthaya. Several are credited with repairing and enriching the Shrine of the Buddha's Footprint, and King Borommakot, who reigned from 1733 to 1758, is said to have restored a number of important temples in the capital. His efforts have not yet been studied in detail, however, and the important task of distinguishing the repairs of his period from the older fabric of temples has hardly begun.

It is difficult to think about the kingdom's last decades without indulging in hindsight and ascribing to those years a sense of decline and impending doom. Many trends were in fact positive. Trade continued to flourish, and imported luxury goods made specifically for Siamese taste, such as high-quality Indian painted and printed cotton textiles and Chinese "five-color" porcelain, were available as never before (cat. nos. 82, 83, 84). Literacy seems to have spread, literature and the performing arts thrived, and cultural and dialectical differences between the capital and the provinces lessened.⁵⁷

Increasingly from the 1750s, however, problems seemed to multiply. The king was getting old, and there was the usual prospect of succession disputes; jostling among potential claimants had already begun. Then the king died and a new king reigned only a few days before abdicating under pressure. As had been the case all too often in the past, the next king could not count on the unified support of the nobles in the capital and the provincial governors, and was unwilling or unable to act decisively. In 1760 Ayutthaya faced a siege by the Burmese that ended only when they withdrew for reasons of their own. But soon enough they returned, capturing one province after another and attacking Ayutthaya from two directions. Famine and plagues weakened the populace; military efforts failed; the city walls gave way, and the invaders destroyed the city.

The human suffering in the next years must have been very great. The country as a whole, however, was pulled back together faster than seemed possible. The Burmese, distracted by conflicts at home, largely withdrew. Though

at first a number of Thai leaders took advantage of the disorder and seized control of various cities, by 1770, just three years after the fall of Ayutthaya, one of them, Taksin, had retaken all the territories of the old kingdom and installed himself as king in a new capital across the river from Bangkok, at Thonburi. Within a few more years he had even secured the vassalage of the Chiang Mai region – the old kingdom of Lan Na. But Taksin, for all his military success, was unable to establish a dynasty. Powerful families with closer connections than he to the ruling elites of Ayutthaya held back their support; meanwhile, it was said, the king indulged in unacceptable religious views and acted cruelly and unpredictably. In 1782 he was deposed by a leader later known as Rama I, who took the throne making Bangkok his capital. Soon the new Siam was as wealthy as, and larger and more powerful than, the old Siam had ever been.⁵⁸ More than two hundred years later, today's king is a distinguished descendent of Rama I.

Though the destruction of Ayutthaya and its aftermath wiped out much of the kingdom's literary, historical, and artistic heritage, some of its artists and artisans survived to take up their tools again. A famous, superbly illustrated manuscript of Buddhist cosmology (figs. 16, 17) was created in Thonburi in 1776, just nine years after the Burmese conquest. Its painters and calligraphers had their training, their apprenticeships, and their early careers in the old kingdom, and witnessed its devastation: they must have lost friends and family members and seen beloved temples and images – perhaps their own works – go up in flames. Their resilience is hard to imagine; even harder to imagine is how they summoned up the calm and radiant playfulness of this great manuscript. They and their descendants were passing on the lifeblood of Ayutthaya's arts to a thriving new kingdom.

NOTES

- 1 *Phra ratchaphongsawadan krung si ayutthaya chabap phan chanthanumat*, 1. I appreciate the advice of Professors Prapod Assavavirulhakarn and Pattaratorn Chirapavati on points of translation. See also Cushman's translation, *Royal Chronicles*, 10. On the Chronicles themselves, see Wyatt, "Chronicle Traditions" and "Introduction to *Chronicle*," and Vickery, "Composition and Transmission." Note that the transcriptions "Ramadhipati" (Rama the supreme lord) and "Ayudhya" reflect Thai spelling (derived from Indic languages), rather than pronunciation, and make clear the references to Rama, the great hero of Indian mythology, and his capital of Ayodhya. "Ramathibodi" and "Ayutthaya" are the same names transcribed to reflect pronunciation, as terms in this book normally are.
- 2 Unlike the kingdoms of Angkor and Sukhothai, Ayutthaya produced very few stone inscriptions. Most documents written

- on light materials perished from fire, rot, or insect damage. For example, whereas from England in the sixteenth century thousands of royal decrees, wills, parish registers, private letters, and other documents of every kind survive, to say nothing of printed books, hardly any documents at all survive from Ayutthaya in the same period.
- 3 Some scholars emphasize the artificiality of the 1351 "foundation" date. "Even though among older secondary sources it is still taken as axiomatic that Ayutthaya was 'established' on 4 March 1351, it has been clear to a growing number of historians that it was a thriving center already much earlier," says Terwiel in the stimulating article "Early Ayutthaya and Foreign Trade" (p. 79), in which he discusses the evidence for substantial activity in the Ayutthaya area before 1351. Some of this evidence is also analyzed in Baker, "Ayutthaya Rising." Note that, as Woodward mentions in his essay in this catalogue, one of Ayutthaya's most important Buddha images is said by the Royal Chronicles to have been constructed some twenty-six years before the city's ceremonial founding.
 - 4 But construction at the Bayon continued into the fourteenth century; Woodward, *Art and Architecture of Thailand*, 202. On the use of Sanskrit, see Pollock, "Cosmopolitan Vernacular," 11–12.
 - 5 Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 119–123, 352–372.
 - 6 See Lieberman, *Strange Parallels* and works cited there. Also, for example, Wyatt, "Relics, Oaths"; Reid, *Early Modern Era*; Wolters, *History, Culture, and Region*; Chaudhuri, *Trade and Civilisation*; Breazeale, ed., *From Japan to Arabia*; and Sunait and Baker, eds., *Recalling Local Pasts*.
 - 7 Wyatt, *Relics, Oaths*, 6–7; Woodward, *Art and Architecture*, 51–54.
 - 8 See Charnvit, "Origins of a Capital," 56–60; and Wyatt, *Relics, Oaths*, 6–7, and the references there. Also, Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 245.
 - 9 Wyatt, *Relics, Oaths*, 5–7. On the meanings of "Thainess," see Thongchai, *Siam Mapped*, 3–9 and *passim*.
 - 10 Vickery, "Khmer Inscriptions," 69; Vickery, "Pitdown 3," 122; Wyatt, *Siam in Mind*, 21–23; Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 177 and nn. 9, 10. The historian David Chandler believes that, "until the end of the sixteenth century, moreover, 'Phnom Penh' (or 'Lovek' or 'Udong' [cities in the vicinity of Phnom Penh, where the capital was located]) and 'Ayudhya' considered themselves not separate polities, but participants in a hybrid culture. . . . Throughout the fourteenth century and much of the fifteenth, the language common to both kingdoms was probably Khmer [Cambodian]" (*History of Cambodia*, 80–81).
 - 11 Wyatt, *Thailand*, 65; Charnvit, *Rise of Ayudhya*, 66–69. See also Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 175.
 - 12 Wyatt, *Relics, Oaths*, 8. In fact, some historians contend that the kingdom of Ayutthaya was a "segmentary state" in which "a number of little kingdoms existed," having varying degrees of autonomy at different times, depending on the strength and influence of the overlord king in the capital; Sunait, "Mandala," 97–98. On the importance of local developments in general, see the essays in Sunait and Baker, eds., *Recalling Local Pasts*. In the arts, certainly into the mid-1500s (cat. no. 42) and as late as a Buddha image from Nakhon Si Thammarat cast in 1671, major sculptures were produced in regional centers in styles related to, but quite distinct from, those of the capital. The 1671 Buddha image is illustrated in Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, fig. 232.
 - 13 The terms in quotation marks come from Wyatt, "Ayutthaya 1409–24," 85. See also his references.
 - 14 Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 175–178; McGill, "Jatakas, Universal Monarchs," 443.
 - 15 Woodward asserts that "it is certain . . . that Phimai occupied a seminal position in the religious heritage of central Thailand. It was at Phimai that the crowned Buddha became established as an iconic type, and the temple must be considered the prototype for the prang [a Cambodian-type temple tower] of central Thailand." See *Art and Architecture in Thailand*, 146–147.
 - 16 Woodward, *Art and Architecture in Thailand*, 166–171. On the possibility of "competing Hinayana sects" in thirteenth-century Siam and Cambodia, see Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 123, and *Art and Architecture in Thailand*, 206.
 - 17 Altered and condensed from Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 521–122.
 - 18 Piriya, "Revised Dating," pt. 1, 49, where the present-day Wat Ratchaburana is attributed to the reign of King Borommakot (1733–1758), and *idem*, "Reassessment," 19. Dr. Piriya makes thought-provoking points, based in part on whether, and how, various buildings in Ayutthaya appear on seventeenth-century European maps and views of the city. The European evidence seems to me too ambiguous or debatable to support the conclusions proposed, given the various sorts of other evidence that support the generally accepted chronology in its broad outlines.
 - 19 Woodward, *Art and Architecture in Thailand*, 222–224. Wat Mahathat (Temple of the Great Relic or of the Great Relic Tower) in Lopburi, like several of the other temples of this name in Thailand, is known today by a more formal name with multiple honorifics: "Wat Phra Si Rattana Mahathat." In this essay the simpler version for the names of the temple in Lopburi and those elsewhere will be used.
 - 20 McGill, *Prasatthong*, 132–135, 142. When the central tower was flanked by two similar but smaller towers, each presumably enshrining a Buddha image, the arrangement would have been prompted by the "Ariya" Buddhist grouping of three Buddhas; Woodward, *Art and Architecture in Thailand*, 171.
 - 21 Tri, *Official Guide*, 42–43.
 - 22 Illustrated in *Phraphuttharup lae phraphim*, figs. 1–8; and *Chitrakam lae sinlapawatthu*, 72. A few early Ayutthaya-period Buddha images show Chinese influence. These images have not received much attention from scholars, and the nature and source of the Chinese influences have not been analyzed. See, for example, a gold relief of a Buddha image from the crypt of Wat Ratchaburana; *Namchom phiphithaphan sathan haeng chat chao sam phraya*, 193.
 - 23 Charnvit, "Origins of a Capital," 67–70; Breazeale, "Thai Maritime Trade," 23.
 - 24 Breazeale, "Thai Maritime Trade," 26–27; Ishii, "Religions Patterns and Economic Change," 182–183; "The Rekidai Hoan: An Introduction." I appreciate Natasha Reichle's calling my attention to the last article.

- 25 Breazeale, "Thai Maritime Trade," 38; Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 254.
- 26 Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 270.
- 27 Chris Baker notes the thinness of the evidence for this "incorporation." He emphasizes the wealth and power retained by several cities of the old Sukhothai kingdom into the early 1500s, and their political and cultural influence on Ayutthaya in the later 1500s; "Ayutthaya Rising," 56–57, 60–62. Such influences have been felt in the arts of Ayutthaya in this period, but they cannot yet be recognized.
- 28 McGill, "Jatakas, Universal Monarchs," 447. The Angkorian bronzes were looted in turn by the Burmese; they are now in Mandalay; Boisselier, "L'Art de bronze," 312–334.
- 29 "For the mainland as a whole, population densities in 1800 were only 10–20 percent those of India, China, or Japan"; Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 27, 212.
- 30 McGill, "Jatakas, Universal Monarchs"; Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 185–186.
- 31 In Lieberman's opinion, "Siamese culture as a distinct complex of practices and dialects crystallized only in the fifteenth or sixteenth century . . ."; *Strange Parallels*, 330, 324.
- 32 These were the towers of Wat Mahathat and Wat Chulamani. Several photos of the tower of Wat Mahathat, Phitsanulok, and a plan of the complex, can be found in *Mahathat*, 36–37, 59, 116. Photos and plans of the tower of Wat Chulamani, together with details of its restoration, are found in *Wat chulamani*.
- 33 Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 185. Roxanna Brown has attributed trade wares from north-central Thailand to the period of approximately 1300–1584; Brown and Sjostrand, *Turiang*, 17. More recently, she has written: "Contrary to my own beliefs that a shortage of Chinese ceramics caused Southeast Asian ceramics to be exported by 1370 or earlier, it is instead the voyages of Zheng He [1404–1433] that appear to have been the primary trigger for expanded trade" (abstract in Asia Research Institute, "Ming Factor").
- 34 Asian Art Museum, *Thai Ceramics*, 13.
- 35 Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 256–257, 268–269; Wyatt, *Thailand*, 88–89.
- 36 Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 186–187.
- 37 Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 18–19; Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 228.
- 38 The characterization is Woodward's, in *Sacred Sculpture*, 228.
- 39 Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 19. Also Phraratchaphongsawadan *krung si ayutthaya chabap phan chanthanumat*, 18.
- 40 Griswold and Prasert, "Inscription of the Śiva," 227–233. Note that the inscription lists other pious acts in addition to the founding of the Hindu images, and dedicates the merit of all of them to "Their Majesties the two kings." Who precisely these kings might have been is discussed by Griswold and Prasert. They also provide a good brief discussion of the place of Hindu deities, and of brahmans, in a Southeast Asian Buddhist court. They downplay any sense of contradiction in a king's patronizing both Buddhism and court ceremonial involving statues of Hindu deities and brahmans.
- 41 See Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 233. A group of these images is illustrated in *Namchom phiphitthaphan sathan haeng chat chao sam phraya*, 85.
- 42 See McGill, *Prasatthong*, 238–239, for a discussion of when crowned and bejeweled Buddha images were made in surrounding kingdoms, and 239–249, for a sketch of the development of the crowned and bejeweled Buddha image in the later Ayutthaya period; also, Woodward, *Sacred Sculpture*, 233. Woodward points out that one of the images in the group probably made around 1500 for Wat Phra Si Sanphet in Ayutthaya (now at Wat Pho in Bangkok) is crowned. He proposes that it may represent Maitreya, the Buddha of the future.
- 43 Woodward presents a related interpretation. Though my suggestion is slightly different from his, it derives from, and is dependent on, ideas he originated. See also, McGill and Pattaratorn, "Art of the Bangkok Period," 30–31.
- 44 Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 214.
- 45 Breazeale, "Maritime Trade"; Nagazumi, "Ayutthaya and Japan"; Andaya, "Muslim Connection"; van der Cruysse, *Siam and the West*.
- 46 Revised from a translation in McGill, *Prasatthong*, 90. The temple is described, analyzed, and illustrated in detail in this dissertation. See also, Prathip, *Wat Chaiwatthanaram*.
- 47 For a different opinion, see Listopad, *Phra Narai*, 29, 462–470.
- 48 Inscriptions on metal sheets attached to the torsos of several of the large crowned and bejeweled Buddha images have dates equivalent to 1649; Prathip, *Wat Chaiwatthanaram*, 153.
- 49 McGill, *Prasatthong*, 138–152.
- 50 "There is no City in the East, where is seen more different Nations, than in the Capital Town of Siam, and where so many different Tongues are spoken," reported France's first ambassador to Siam in 1685; Chaumont, quoted in Smithies, "Stormy Relationship," 147. For an overview of the changes in Ayutthaya's rank as a trading center, see the chapter titled "Documenting the Rise and Fall of Ayudhya as a Regional Trade Center" in Reid, *Early Modern Era*.
- 51 See, for example, Wyatt's "A Persian Mission to Siam in the Reign of King Narai" and "Family Politics in Seventeenth- and Eighteenth-Century Siam" in *Studies in Thai History*.
- 52 Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 143, 245, 247. On images of Ganesha, see the entry for cat. no. 40. On the arts of Narai's period in general, see Listopad, *Phra Narai*; Le Bonheur, *Phra Narai*.
- 53 McGill and Pattaratorn, "Art of the Bangkok Period," 30–31.
- 54 Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 288 and 289–298.
- 55 But see two articles on the renovation of Wat Pa Mok in 1727: Griswold, "Eighteenth-Century Monastery"; and Griswold and Luang Boribal, "Devices and Expedients." Also, Santi, *Stucco Motifs*.
- 56 On pilgrimages to the Shrine of the Buddha's Footprint, see Raben and Dhiravat, *In the King's Trail*. On kings' fishing, see Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 384, 399, 405. Fishing was the least of the crimes of "King Tiger." According to the *Chronicles*, he repeatedly committed rape and murder; Cushman, *Royal Chronicles*, 373, 391.
- 57 On the structural and economic strengths and weaknesses of the late-Ayutthaya and early Bangkok periods, see Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 286–230; Dhiravat, "Shift to Isolation?"
- 58 See Wenk, *Restoration of Thailand*; Wyatt, "The 'Subtle Revolution' of King Rama I of Siam," in *Studies in Thai History*.